



APPLICATION NOTE

Single-port I2C/SMBus/I3C operation for NVMe-MI on Binho Supernova

AN0014

Document information

Keywords	AN0014, Supernova, I3C, I2C, SMBus, MCTP, clock stretching, legacy I2C, tTIMEOUT, NVMe-MI, ARP, Hot-Join, PIC18F16Q20, pyCosmicSDK
Abstract	Many SMBus and MCTP devices hold SCL low while they prepare a response. The Supernova's I3C engine cannot wait for that, so on its I3C port such a target used to lose bits. Adapter firmware 4.6.0 and pyCosmicSDK 1.6.0 add a mode in which legacy I2C transfers on the I3C port wait for the target, up to the SMBus 35 ms timeout. This note explains the mode, supplies a script that reads and writes a stretching target with it, and supplies the firmware of the reference target used to measure it: 1200 of 1200 reads correct at 100 kHz and 400 kHz, with the target stretching from 0 to 30 ms, and every stretched read correct up to the mode's ceiling of 746 kHz. The script also runs the SMBus to I3C Basic detection flow of the PCI-SIG out-of-band management specification as far as the adapter can.

1 Introduction

An I2C target may hold SCL low after it acknowledges its address, to gain time before it answers. The controller must wait until SCL is released. The I2C specification calls this clock stretching, and SMBus allows it for up to 35 ms (tTIMEOUT). SMBus and MCTP devices use it routinely: a management controller that is fetching a value holds the clock until the value is ready.

The Supernova's I3C port can address legacy I2C targets on the same bus as I3C devices. Its I3C engine, however, keeps clocking while a target holds SCL low, so a stretching target misses bits and the transfer returns wrong data or no acknowledge. Adapter firmware 4.6.0 and pyCosmicSDK 1.6.0 add a mode that fixes this for legacy I2C transfers on the I3C port.

1.1 Scope

This document covers:

- what the clock-stretching mode changes, and what it refuses while it is on
- the SCL rates it runs at and how close they come to the request
- a script that reads and writes a stretching target through the mode
- a reference target that stretches for a configurable time, and its firmware
- measured results against that target
- the SMBus to I3C Basic detection flow used for NVMe-MI, and which of its steps the adapter performs

It does not cover SMBus framing beyond the PEC check of an ARP Get UDID (block read and write, quick command), MCTP or NVMe-MI messages, or the Supernova's separate I2C port.

1.2 Applicable devices

Table 1. Applicable devices

Role	Part	Identifier	Basis
Controller	Binho Supernova	hardware revision C, firmware 4.6.0 pre-release build <code>def51e1c</code> , I3C HV port	measured, this document
Controller	Binho Supernova	firmware 4.5.1 or earlier	refuses the mode with <code>FW_UNSUPPORTED_COMMAND</code>
Controller	Binho Pulsar	any	not applicable: the Pulsar has no I3C port
Reference target	Microchip PIC18F16Q20 Curiosity Nano	firmware <code>stretch_target_pic18q20.c</code>	measured, this document

Note: this revision was written against pre-release builds. The firmware reports its version as 4.5.1 with a build suffix because the version string had not yet been moved to 4.6.0. The mode and its behavior are those of the 4.6.0 release.

1.3

Related documents

Table 2. Related documents

Document	Title
UM10204	I2C-bus specification and user manual, Rev. 7, NXP Semiconductors
SMBus 3.2	System Management Bus Specification, version 3.2
PCI-SIG ECN	PCI-SIG Engineering Change Notice: Chapter 12. Architectural Out-of-Band Management
AN0015	Setting the I2C SCL duty cycle and an exact bus frequency with the Binho Supernova and Pulsar

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System overview

With the mode off, `legacy_i2c_read` and `legacy_i2c_write` on the I3C port are carried out by the I3C engine, which drives SCL on its own schedule. With the mode on, the adapter's firmware clocks those transfers in software and checks SCL after every phase it releases. When a target holds SCL low, the firmware waits.

Four facts shape how the mode is used:

- **It is a mode, not a per-transfer option.** `enable_i2c_clock_stretching(frequency_hz)` turns it on for every later legacy I2C transfer; `disable_i2c_clock_stretching()` turns it off. `initialize` and `configure` also turn it off.
- **It excludes I3C traffic.** While it is on, SDR, HDR and CCC calls, `init_bus` and `reset_bus` raise `I3cError` with status `FW_I3C_I2C_CLOCK_STRETCHING_ACTIVE`. Turn it off before talking to an I3C device.
- **It enforces the SMBus timeout.** A stretch longer than 35 ms ends the transfer with `FW_BUS_TIMEOUT`, and the bus is released.
- **The rate is never above the request.** The call returns the rate in effect. It is 10 kHz to 1 MHz; at 100 kHz the adapter runs at 97975 Hz, at 400 kHz at 391644 Hz. The software clock tops out at 746268 Hz, so 800 kHz and 1 MHz requests both run there.

3 Hardware setup

3.1 Required equipment

Table 3. Required equipment

Item
Binho Supernova, firmware 4.6.0 or later
USB-C cable
An I2C or SMBus target that stretches SCL, or the reference target of section 3.4
Pull-up resistors on SCL and SDA, if the target board has none

3.2 Connections

Table 4. Connections between the Supernova I3C HV port and the target

Supernova I3C HV port	Target	Required
SCL	SCL	required
SDA	SDA	required
GND	GND	required
VTARG	target I/O supply	optional, if the target is powered from the adapter

3.3 Bus considerations

The I3C port has no pull-up on SCL. An I2C bus needs one on both lines. On our bench it came from a Binho Pulsar's I2C port set to 1 kOhm and left idle; a pair of 1 kOhm to 2.2 kOhm resistors to the bus voltage does the same job. Without a pull-up on SCL the reported rate drops sharply, because the firmware waits for every rising edge.

Caution: the I3C HV port selects its voltage from `set_voltage` : 1200 mV to 3300 mV. Set it to the target's I/O voltage before connecting a target that is not 3.3 V tolerant.

Caution: only one controller on the bus. If a second adapter supplies the pull-up, do not start transfers from it.

3.4 The reference target

To measure the mode we needed a target whose stretch we could set.

`stretch_target_pic18q20.c`, in the assets archive, turns a PIC18F16Q20 Curiosity Nano into one. Its I2C peripheral holds SCL after every address match for a programmable time, which is how a busy SMBus device behaves.

Table 5. Reference target protocol, address 0x2A

Transfer	Effect
write 0xF0, low byte, high byte	stretch that many microseconds after every later address match; 0 turns stretching off
read	returns 0xA5 for every byte
any other write	accepted and discarded

SCL and SDA are on RB6 and RB5. Build it with MPLAB XC8 and program it with MPLAB X or the Curiosity Nano's drag-and-drop programmer.

4 Software setup

Install pyCosmicSDK 1.6.0 or later:

```
pip install "pycosmicsdk>=1.6.0"
```

The script `smbus_stretch.py` is in the assets archive. It needs nothing else.

5 The clock-stretching mode

5.1 Using it

The calls in isolation:

```
import pycosmicsdk as p

dev = p.Device.open(model=p.DeviceModel.SUPERNOVA)
i3c = dev.i3c()
i3c.set_voltage(voltage_mv=3300)
i3c.bring_up(
    push_pull_rate=p.I3cPushPullRate.PUSH_PULL_1_MHZ_DC_40,
    open_drain_rate=p.I3cOpenDrainRate.OPEN_DRAIN_100_KHZ,
    i2c_open_drain_rate=p.I2cOpenDrainRate.STANDARD_MODE,
)
print(i3c.enable_i2c_clock_stretching(100_000))
# I2cClockStretching(enabled=True, frequency_hz=97975)
data = i3c.legacy_i2c_read(0x2A, 16)
i3c.disable_i2c_clock_stretching()
```

A register read, the SMBus Read Byte or Read Word pattern, passes the register as `subaddress`: `i3c.legacy_i2c_read(0x0B, 2, subaddress=bytes([0x09]))`.

5.2 Status codes

Table 6. Status codes specific to the mode

Status	Raised by	Meaning
<code>FW_UNSUPPORTED_COMMAND</code>	enable, disable	firmware 4.5.1 or earlier
<code>FW_INVALID_PARAMETER</code>	enable	rate outside 10 kHz to 1 MHz
<code>FW_INTERFACE_NOT_INITIALIZED</code>	enable, disable	the I3C controller was not brought up
<code>FW_I3C_I2C_CLOCK_STRETCHING_ACTIVE</code>	SDR, HDR, CCC, <code>init_bus</code> , <code>reset_bus</code>	the mode is on; turn it off first
<code>FW_BUS_TIMEOUT</code>	legacy read or write	the target held SCL longer than 35 ms

5.3 The SMBus timeout

During firmware validation, with the reference target set to stretch 40 ms, 100 reads returned 50 `FW_BUS_TIMEOUT` and 50 `FW_I3C_NACK_ADDRESS`, the longest in 46 ms, and the adapter stayed responsive. The address NACKs come from the target, which misses the next address while it is still counting out its 40 ms.

6 Procedure

1. Connect the target and the pull-ups as in section 3.2. Power the target.
2. Read from the target. The first line shows the firmware and the rate in effect:

```
$ python smbus_stretch.py read 0x2A 16
FW-4.5.1-def51e1c I3C port 3300 mV stretching on, SCL 97975 Hz
read 0x2A: a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5 a5
```

3. Write to it:

```
$ python smbus_stretch.py write 0x2A 0x01 0x02 0x03
FW-4.5.1-def51e1c I3C port 3300 mV stretching on, SCL 97975 Hz
write 0x2A: 01 02 03
```

4. With the reference target, sweep the stretch. For each duration the script sets the target's stretch, reads 16 bytes 100 times, and checks every byte:

```
$ python smbus_stretch.py sweep
FW-4.5.1-def51e1c I3C port 3300 mV stretching on, SCL 97975 Hz
stretch reads ok median ms result
    0 us   100 100      6.19 all bytes correct
    50 us   100 100      6.79 all bytes correct
   500 us   100 100      7.13 all bytes correct
  2000 us   100 100      9.26 all bytes correct
 10000 us   100 100     17.89 all bytes correct
 30000 us   100 100     39.05 all bytes correct
```

5. Repeat at 400 kHz:

```
$ python smbus_stretch.py --kHz 400 sweep
FW-4.5.1-def51e1c I3C port 3300 mV stretching on, SCL 391644 Hz
stretch reads ok median ms result
    0 us   100 100      5.08 all bytes correct
    50 us   100 100      5.04 all bytes correct
   500 us   100 100      6.35 all bytes correct
  2000 us   100 100      8.46 all bytes correct
 10000 us   100 100     16.78 all bytes correct
 30000 us   100 100     37.92 all bytes correct
```

The median time per read grows with the stretch, and by about the stretch: the adapter waited each time. The script sets the target's stretch back to 0 before it exits.

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The SMBus to I3C Basic detection flow

NVMe-MI devices that move from SMBus to I3C Basic share one pair of pins, so the host has to find out which protocol each device speaks before it changes the bus. The flow the host follows is defined in the PCI-SIG Engineering Change Notice, Chapter 12, Architectural Out-of-Band Management. The `handoff` command of `smbus_stretch.py` runs it on the Supernova I3C port. Table 7 lists the steps and who performs each.

Table 7. Detection flow steps

Step	Flow	Performed by
1	Broadcast DISEC with DISHJ to 7Eh at the SMBus voltage; ACK means an I3C Basic device is present	script. Only the 7Eh header is open-drain; the CCC byte and data are push-pull at the I3C rate. A NACK is reported as <code>FW_I3C_NACK_ADDRESS</code>
2	SMBus device discovery at static addresses and at 61h (ARP Get UDID)	script, with the clock-stretching mode on. The script checks the PEC
3	An SMBus-only device was found: reset the SMBus interface and stay in SMBus mode	hardware: hold SCL low for T2wrst, or pulse SMRST#. Firmware 4.6.0 has no command that holds SCL low for a set time
4	DISEC with DISHJ again, then SMBus pull-ups off and I3C Basic pull-ups on	script for DISEC. The pull-ups are external: the I3C port has no pull-up it can switch
5	Wait Tsmb2i3c, move to the I3C Basic voltage, broadcast ENEC with ENHJ	script. <code>--t-smb2i3c-ms</code> and <code>--i3c-voltage-mv</code> come from the specification and the device
6	The device Hot-Joins	firmware: it assigns the dynamic address itself and the script prints it

The clock-stretching mode refuses every CCC (section 5.2), so the script turns it on for step 2 only and off again before step 4.

Note: only the SMBus-only branch has been run, 5 of 5 identical, on the bench of section 9.1: step 1 NACKed, step 2 found the reference target at 0x2A and no ARP device. Steps 3 to 6 need a device that ACKs 7Eh and Hot-Joins, and the ARP and PEC path needs an ARP-capable device; neither was on the bench. The PEC routine is checked against the CRC-8/SMBUS check value only.

```
$ python smbus_stretch.py --khz 400 handoff --address 0x2A 0x2B
FW-4.5.1-8df61a39 I3C port 3300 mV (SMBus voltage)
1. DISEC(DISHJ) to 7Eh: NACK, SMBus only
2. SMBus discovery, stretching on, SCL 391644 Hz
   static 0x2A: ACK
   static 0x2B: FW_I3C_NACK_ADDRESS
   ARP 0x61 Get UDID: FW_I3C_NACK_ADDRESS (no ARP-capable device)
   SMBus mode stays. To reset the interface, hold SCL low for T2wrst or pulse
   SMRST#.
```

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Reference

Table 8. smbus_stretch.py options

Option	Default	Meaning
<code>--serial</code>	any	Supernova serial number
<code>--voltage-mv</code>	3300	I3C port voltage, 1200 to 3300 for the HV connector
<code>--khz</code>	100	SCL rate, 10 to 1000; runs at 746 kHz at most

Table 9. smbus_stretch.py commands

Command	Arguments	Action
<code>read</code>	address, length, optional <code>--register</code>	read, optionally after writing one register byte
<code>write</code>	address, bytes	write the bytes
<code>sweep</code>	<code>--address</code> , <code>--count</code> , <code>--length</code>	reference target only: stretch 0, 50, 500, 2000, 10000 and 30000 us, <code>--count</code> reads each
<code>handoff</code>	<code>--address</code> , <code>--i3c-voltage-mv</code> , <code>--t-smb2i3c-ms</code> , <code>--hj-timeout-s</code> , <code>--no-smbus-only</code> , <code>--yes</code>	the detection flow of section 7

Every command enables the mode before its transfers and disables it before exiting, so the I3C port is usable for I3C traffic afterwards.

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Measured results

9.1

Test configuration

Table 10. Test configuration

Item	Value
Adapter	Binho Supernova, hardware revision C. Firmware <code>FW-4.5.1-def51e1c</code> (4.6.0 pre-release) for section 6, <code>FW-4.5.1-044a3b69</code> (fw-hostadapters#150 at <code>07528cc5</code>) for the rates above 400 kHz, <code>FW-4.5.1-8df61a39</code> for section 7
Host software	pyCosmicSDK 1.6.0 pre-release, <code>integration/1.6.0</code> at <code>baacfdba</code> , Linux
Bus	I3C HV port, 3.3 V, 1 kOhm pull-up on SCL and SDA from an idle Binho Pulsar
Target	PIC18F16Q20 Curiosity Nano, <code>stretch_target_pic18q20.c</code> , address 0x2A

9.2

Results

The sweeps of section 6 read 1200 times, 16 bytes each, across both rates and six stretch durations: 1200 correct, no errors.

Further results from the firmware validation of the same feature, on earlier builds:

- Soak with random 1 to 64 byte reads and writes, the stretch changing every 100 transfers among 0, 50 us, 500 us, 2 ms and 10 ms: 0 bad reads in about 3400 stretched transfers per run at 100 kHz and 400 kHz, including a run after a power cycle.
- Measured on the wire at a 1 kOhm pull-up: a 100 kHz request runs at 97.9 kHz and a 400 kHz request at 391.4 kHz, with tLOW and tHIGH at or above the UM10204 minimums.

Above 400 kHz, with the target stretching 50 us to 30 ms, 20 reads of 16 bytes per point:

Table 11. Rates above 400 kHz

Request	Reported	On the wire	tLOW / tHIGH	Stretched reads
400 kHz	391644 Hz	394.5 kHz	1625 / 910 ns	100 of 100
600 kHz	581395 Hz	561.8 kHz	965 / 820 ns	100 of 100
800 kHz	746268 Hz	754.7 kHz	815 / 515 ns	100 of 100, and 100 of 100 after each of 3 resets
1 MHz	746268 Hz	not measured	not measured	100 of 100

On-the-wire values are medians over about 23000 SCL periods on an Acute logic analyzer. At 800 kHz both phases stay above the UM10204 Fast-mode Plus minimums of 500 ns and 260 ns. At 600 kHz the reported rate is 3.5 % above the wire.

With the reference target not stretching, reads above 400 kHz return 0xFF in the second byte, 0 of 100 at each rate, while every stretched read is correct. The adapter's SCL is the same in both cases; only the target's own clock stretching is off. We attribute it to the reference target's firmware not loading the second byte in time without stretching, not to the adapter.

These are what we measured on one bench, not a specification.

Note: on the pre-release builds, the first `enable_i2c_clock_stretching` after an `init_bus` that failed (no I3C device answered) may report about half the rate at 100 kHz, or time out at 10 kHz. The rate on the wire is correct. This is being fixed for the release; the procedure above does not call `init_bus`.

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Troubleshooting

Table 12. Troubleshooting

Symptom	Probable cause and action
<code>FW_UNSUPPORTED_COMMAND</code> on enable	Firmware 4.5.1 or earlier. Update the Supernova to 4.6.0 or later.
Reported rate far below the request	No pull-up on SCL. Add one (section 3.3).
<code>FW_I3C_I2C_CLOCK_STRETCHING_ACTIVE</code>	An I3C call was made with the mode on. Call <code>disable_i2c_clock_stretching</code> first.
<code>FW_BUS_TIMEOUT</code>	The target held SCL longer than 35 ms. Check the target; this is SMBus tTIMEOUT.
<code>FW_I3C_NACK_ADDRESS</code> right after reconfiguring the reference target	The target restarts its I2C peripheral to apply a new stretch. The script waits 10 ms for this.
Wrong data from a stretching target with the mode off	Expected: the I3C engine does not wait. Turn the mode on.
<code>FW_INVALID_PARAMETER</code> on enable above 400 kHz	Firmware before 4.6.0's 1 MHz limit. Update the Supernova.
<code>handoff</code> step 1 NACK with an I3C Basic device on the bus	The device is not in SMBus mode at the voltage set, or not powered. Check <code>--voltage-mv</code> .

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Acronyms

Table 13. Acronyms

Term	Meaning
I2C	Inter-Integrated Circuit
I3C	MIPI Improved Inter-Integrated Circuit
SMBus	System Management Bus
MCTP	Management Component Transport Protocol
SCL	Serial clock line
SDA	Serial data line
SDR	Single data rate, the base I3C transfer mode
HDR	High data rate I3C transfer modes
CCC	I3C common command code
tTIMEOUT	SMBus clock-low timeout, 35 ms
ARP	SMBus Address Resolution Protocol
PEC	SMBus packet error code, a CRC-8
UDID	SMBus unique device identifier
DISEC, ENEC	I3C CCCs that disable and enable target events
Hot-Join	I3C event in which a target joins the bus and receives a dynamic address
NVMe-MI	NVM Express Management Interface
T2wrst, Tsmb2i3c	timing parameters of the PCI-SIG detection flow

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Note about the source code in the document

Example code shown in this document and supplied in the accompanying archive is provided for evaluation and reference. It is released under the MIT license, the text of which is included in the archive.

The archive `AN0014-assets.zip` contains `smbus_stretch.py`, `stretch_target_pic18q20.c` and `LICENSE`.

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Revision history

Table 14. Revision history

Revision	Date	Description
0.1	25 September 2026	Draft for internal review, measured on firmware 4.6.0 and pyCosmicSDK 1.6.0 pre-release builds.
0.2	28 September 2026	Retitled for NVMe-MI. Rates up to 1 MHz (746 kHz in effect). Section 7, the SMBus to I3C Basic detection flow, and the <code>handoff</code> command.

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Draft

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